

DATABRICKS

Data + AI Platform

Databricks Role-Based Certifications

A Practical Guide — What They Are, Why They Matter,
How to Get Them

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Databricks certifications are official exams that prove you can actually **do** a specific job on the Databricks platform — not just recognize terminology. Each certification maps to a real role (data engineer, data analyst, ML engineer, etc.) rather than testing generic platform trivia.

In practice, this means the exams are **scenario-based**: you're given a realistic situation and asked to choose the best solution — closer to a decision-making test than a memorization quiz. This is worth understanding up front, because it changes how you should prepare: reading documentation alone is not enough; you need to have actually built things.

Two Tiers

Tier	Cost	Proctored	Weight with employers	Validity
Certifications	\$200	Yes	Highest	2 years
Accreditations	Free	No	Lighter-weight badge	—

In short: accreditations are a good way to build a foundation and get comfortable with the platform, but certifications are the credential that actually carries weight — they're paid, proctored, and time-boxed to keep the signal meaningful.

Five reasons this is worth the investment of time and the \$200 exam fee:

Proof, not claims

A resume line saying "experienced with Databricks" is a claim. A certification is independent, third-party evidence of hands-on skill — it removes the guesswork for whoever is evaluating you, whether that's a manager, a client, or a hiring panel.

Growing demand

More companies are adopting the Databricks Lakehouse platform every year, which means the pool of roles asking for this specific skill set keeps expanding — certification positions you ahead of that curve rather than catching up later.

Pay & career impact

Certified professionals tend to see higher average pay and get considered first for promotions. The credential acts as an objective marker when those decisions are being made.

Portable

Unlike internal project experience, the credential travels with you — it's independent of any one employer or project, so it keeps its value even if your role or company changes.

Focus

Studying for the exam forces you to fill in real gaps in your knowledge rather than just the parts of the platform you happen to use day to day. You end up better at the job either way, independent of whether the certificate itself gets used.

The path from "never touched Databricks" to "certified" follows the same seven steps regardless of which track you choose:

1. Pick the track

Choose the certification that matches your actual role — see the comparison table in Section 5, or the decision guide in Section 7.

2. (Optional) Start free

The Lakehouse Platform Fundamentals accreditation is a good primer if you're new to the platform. It is not required before sitting an Associate exam, but it removes a lot of the initial confusion.

3. Study

Use Databricks Academy — the official, free self-paced courses are built to align directly with each exam guide, so this is the most efficient starting point.

4. Practice hands-on

Build real pipelines or notebooks in a free Databricks Community Edition or trial workspace. This step matters more than it might seem: these exams reward real experience over rote learning, so skipping hands-on practice is the most common reason people fail.

5. Review the official exam guide

Read the exact topics and their weighting before booking the exam. This tells you exactly where to concentrate your remaining study time.

6. Sit the exam

Online proctored, or at a test center. Multiple choice. 90–120 minutes depending on whether it's an Associate or Professional level exam.

7. Result

Pass/fail, with a domain-by-domain breakdown showing where you were strong or weak. The certificate and digital badge are issued within roughly 24 hours.

Every paid certification exam is a flat **\$200 USD** (excluding tax), regardless of whether it's an Associate or Professional level exam — the price does not scale with difficulty.

There are **no free retakes**. A failed attempt means paying the \$200 fee again, and there's roughly a **14-day mandatory wait** before you can rebook. This makes the hands-on practice step in Section 3 especially important — going in underprepared is an expensive way to find out what you don't know.

Certifications are valid for **2 years**, after which recertification is required to keep the credential current with the platform. Free accreditations (Lakehouse Fundamentals, Platform Administrator, and the cloud Platform Architect badges) cost nothing and don't carry this recertification requirement in the same way.

Full Certification List

All certifications below cost **\$200** and are valid for **2 years**. Duration and question count vary by level — Associate exams are shorter, Professional exams are longer and go deeper.

Certification	Best for	Duration	Qs	Key topics
Data Analyst Associate	BI / analytics roles	90 min	45	Databricks SQL, dashboards, AI/BI Genie, Unity Catalog, data modeling & security
Data Engineer Associate	Entry-level data engineering	90 min	45	Ingestion & loading, transformation, Lakeflow Jobs, CI/CD basics, governance
Data Engineer Professional	Senior / advanced engineering	120 min	59	Python/SQL pipelines, performance tuning, security & governance, monitoring, data sharing
Machine Learning Associate	Entry-level ML on Databricks	90 min	48	ML basics, data processing, model development & deployment
Machine Learning Professional	Production ML / MLOps	120 min	59	Spark ML model development, MLOps, production deployment
Generative AI Engineer Associate	RAG apps & LLM chains	90 min	45	Design, data prep, app development, deployment, governance, evaluation — Vector Search, Model Serving, MLflow
Associate Developer for Apache Spark	Spark coding roles	—	—	Spark fundamentals, DataFrame API, transformations (PySpark/Scala)

Cost: \$200 each • **Validity:** 2 years • **Retakes:** full price, ~14-day wait • **Format:** online proctored, multiple choice

Accreditations are **not proctored** and carry lighter employer recognition than a paid certification, but they're free and a genuinely good way to build a foundation before committing \$200 to an Associate exam.

Accreditation	What it covers
Lakehouse Platform Fundamentals	General introduction to the Databricks platform — recommended (not required) before sitting Associate exams
Platform Administrator	User & role management, cluster administration, Unity Catalog governance
Platform Architect badges (AWS / Azure / GCP)	Cloud-specific setup: IAM, storage integration (S3/ADLS/GCS), networking, cost optimization

Which One Should I Get?

The right starting point depends entirely on the role you're in (or the one you want to move toward). Use this as a quick lookup:

If you are...	Start with
New to Databricks, generalist	Lakehouse Fundamentals (free) → Data Engineer Associate
SQL / BI-leaning	Data Analyst Associate
Building pipelines day to day	Data Engineer Associate → Data Engineer Professional
Doing ML work on Databricks	ML Associate → ML Professional
Building RAG apps / AI agents	Data Engineer or ML Associate first, then GenAI Engineer Associate
Writing Spark code specifically	Associate Developer for Apache Spark

Note the pattern in the GenAI row: it's generally worth having a Data Engineer or ML foundation before jumping straight into GenAI Engineer Associate, since RAG applications and LLM chains build directly on top of those data-handling skills.

Databricks Academy (academy.databricks.com)

The official, free self-paced courses, aligned to each exam guide, plus paid instructor-led options for teams that want structured, live training.

Official exam guides (PDFs on databricks.com)

The exact topics tested and how much each is worth. This is the most reliable source — third-party study guides can lag behind when Databricks updates an exam.

Hands-on practice

A free Databricks Community Edition or trial workspace. Worth repeating: these exams test real scenarios, not recall, so this step isn't optional if you want to pass comfortably.

Practice question banks

Sites like DataCamp, Udemy, Whizlabs, and Prepzee. Useful for getting comfortable with the exam format and question style — but treat them as familiarization, not a substitute for hands-on practice or the official exam guide.

Pick the track that matches the role you do (or want to do), study free via Databricks Academy, practice hands-on in a real workspace, and budget **\$200** per exam attempt. Certifications last **2 years** before you need to recertify.